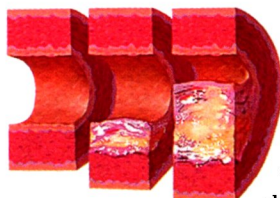




# The Cholesterol TRAP

You need the waxy cholesterol to maintain cellular membranes, make hormones and a lot more. But too much is bad for you.

## The Big Issue



For a country slated to lose productivity worth \$237 billion between 2005 and 2015 due to coronary problems in the young workforce, lowering LDL (bad) cholesterol is the top priority.

An executive check-up on 1,16,731 corporate employees last year by Apollo Hospitals revealed high cholesterol levels among 51 per cent.



## Money Spinner

Cholesterol-lowering drugs, statins, are top-sellers, not just in India but globally, with drugmakers earning billions every year from these. Patients end up spending a fortune on them, as most such drugs are prescribed for five to seven years, if not a lifetime. They typically cost Rs 15 a day.

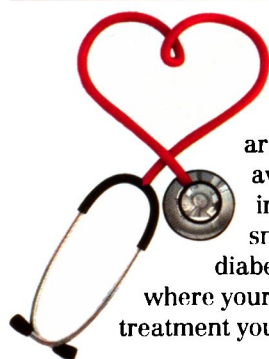
## The Statin Debate

Statin, however, are among the most debated treatments. Many contest the cholesterol-heart attack link. The repeated lowering of recommended LDL and Total Cholesterol levels by the medical community has created confusion. Many believe cholesterol and statins are overhyped by the pharma industry.



## Diet Chart

Despite the confusion, diet remains the top way to attack high cholesterol. A Harvard University study mentions 11 foods that either provide soluble fibre and drag cholesterol out of the body, or polyunsaturated fats that lower LDL or block cholesterol absorption. These are: oats, beans, brinjals, nuts like almonds and walnuts, vegetable oils, apples, grapes and citrus fruits, food fortified with sterols and stanols, soy, fatty fish and fibre supplements.

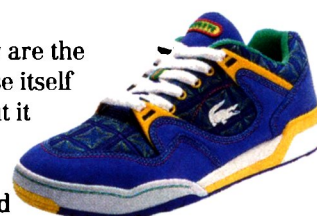


## Know Your Risk

It is important to know what your total cholesterol, LDL and HDL are. However, you should also be aware of your overall risk—for instance, your family history, smoking, blood pressure and diabetes. Your overall risk determines where your LDL should be and what treatment you might need.

## Burn the Fat

Weight loss and physical activity are the cornerstones of therapy. Exercise itself does not burn off cholesterol, but it can reduce triglycerides and stimulate several metabolic enzyme systems in the muscles and liver to convert some of the cholesterol to a more favourable form—such as HDL cholesterol.



■ Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**